Petrov was the ranking duty officer on September 26, 1983. Just past midnight, the early warning radar alarm sounded, and Petrov looked up to see a single US ballistic missile being tracked inbound toward the Soviet Union. Petrov had just fifteen minutes to decide whether the attack was real—fifteen minutes after that, the first warhead would detonate over Soviet soil. A few minutes later, another alarm sounded, and the screens warned that four more US ICBMs were rocketing toward Russia. Once Petrov confirmed that a nuclear attack was imminent, Soviet leaders would almost certainly order an equally devastating counterstrike on US and European territory.

Despite unimaginable pressure and the near panic of those around him, Petrov did not believe the attack was real. Based on what Soviet nuclear officers thought they understood about US nuclear doctrine, a surprise first strike would be massive, designed to destroy the USSR's retaliatory capability. Unlike a "first use" attack, in which one country that is feeling threatened with nuclear attack by an adversary during a crisis decides to launch nuclear missiles preemptively, a first strike could come out of the blue, in overwhelming force. On that early September morning in 1983, just five US missiles did not make sense to Petrov. But if he was wrong, then not only would the Soviet Union soon suffer at least five thermonuclear detonations but there might not be enough time to retaliate if the Soviet leadership or key command and control nodes were destroyed.

Petrov decided the alarm was a false one. With bated breath, he and his subordinates waited to see if he had made the wrong call. When no reports came in of warheads detonating on Soviet soil, they could breathe again, shaken to the core by the realization that they had come to within perhaps minutes of a global thermonuclear exchange. A later investigation to determine why the false alarm occurred concluded that Soviet early warning satellites had incorrectly identified sunlight glinting off cloud tops as the flashes of US ICBMs being launched.

North Korea will not have any early warning satellites, at least that we know of, but it will face the same question of correctly identifying perceived threats and deciding how to respond, whether during periods